

a' and his days will be one hundred and twenty years."

- a 4 **The Nephilim** were **in the land** in those days,
and also afterward,
b when **the sons of Elohim** went
c into the **daughters of humanity**
c' and they **bore children**
b' **to/for them** ;
a' **these are the mighty warriors** who are from ancient time, men of the name.

The Rebellion of the Sons of Adam

- a 5 **And Yahweh saw** that **multiplied (רב)** was the badness of **humanity** **in the land** ,
b and every purpose of the plans of **his heart** was only bad all the day,
a' 6 and Yahweh **regretted that he made** **humanity** **in the land** .
b' And he was pained in **his heart**.

- 7 **And Yahweh said** ,
"I will wipe away **humanity** that I created from the face of **the ground** ,
from **humanity**
to animals
to creeping things
and to birds of the skies
for **I regret that I have made** them."

8 And/But Noah found favor **in the eyes of Yahweh**.

- a 9 These are the **birth**-generations of Noah;
Noah was a righteous one,
b blameless in his generation;
Noah walked with *Elohim*;
a 10 and Noah **birthed** three sons: Shem, Ham, and Japheth.

- a 11 And **the land** was **ruined** **before Elohim**.
b And **the land** was filled with violence,
a' 12 and **Elohim saw** **the land** : and behold, **it** was **ruined** ,
b' for **all flesh** had **ruined** its/his way upon **the land** .

Genesis 6:1-12 and Genesis 3

Both units of 6:1-4 and 6:5-12 contain coordinated hyperlinks back to the original creation blessing bestowed on humanity ([Gen. 1:1-2:3](#)) and to the tragic forfeit of that blessing in Genesis 3:6. The behavior of the sons of God mirrors the behavior of Eve in Genesis 3, while the “seeing” of Yahweh in Genesis 1 sadly contrasts what he sees in Genesis 6.

Genesis 1:1-2:3 - Good Multiplied

"And God saw that it was **good**" [7x]

"And God blessed them, 'Be fruitful and **multiply** (רבה), **fill the land** (מלא + ארץ)."

Genesis 3:6 - First Fail Narrative

And **the woman saw** (ראה) **that the tree was** **good** (כי טוב) for eating and that it was enticing to the eyes and it was desirable for gaining wisdom,

and she took (לקח) its fruit and she ate and she gave to her husband with her and he ate.

Genesis 6:1-2 - Capstone Fail Narrative

And it came about when **humanity began to multiply** (רבה) on the face of **the land** (ארץ)

... and **the sons of God saw** (ויראו), **the daughters of humanity** (בנות האדם) **that they were** **good** (כי טוב), **and they took** (לקח) for themselves wives from all which they chose.

Genesis 6:5 & 6:11 - Evil Multiplied

"And Yahweh saw (וירא) **that** (כי) **multiplied** (רבה) was **the evil** of humanity (האדם רעת) in the land (ארץ).

"And **the land** (ארץ) was ruined before God, and **the land was filled** (מלא + ארץ) with violence."

Mirrored Phrases in Genesis 1, 3, and 6. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

The twin introductions to the flood narrative consist of two literary units, 6:1-4 and 6:5-8, both carefully shaped to coordinate with each other in a narrative analogy.

- Genesis 6:1-4: Humanity's multiplication leads to rebel spiritual beings seeing and taking human women.
- Genesis 6:5-8: Yahweh sees that, as a result of 6:1-4, evil and violence have multiplied in the land.

Both of these analogies depend on the narrative analogy in Genesis 1-3. When we recognize this, the analogies deepen.

Genesis 1 is designed to answer these core questions. We are going to tackle these questions in three large steps.

1. The sons of God and daughters of men / Eve and the snake
2. The daughters of men / The tree of knowing good and bad
3. The blessing and multiplication of humans on the land in Genesis 1 is sadly turned into a multiplication of death in Genesis 6

GENESIS 6

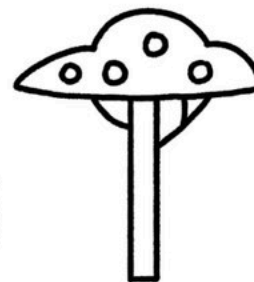
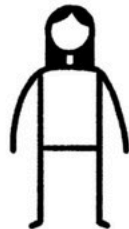
SPIRITUAL BEINGS



SEE GOOD/TAKE



GENESIS 3



Genesis 6 Mirrors Genesis 3. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Recommended Resource

For a helpful theory of worldview statements, we recommend J. Richard Middleton and Brian Walsh's book, [*Truth is Stranger Than It Used to Be: Biblical Faith in a Postmodern Age*](#).

Reflection Question

What observations did you have as we read through Genesis 6:1-12?

Session 8: The Rebellion of the Sons of *Elohim*

Key Takeaways

- The idiomatic phrase “sons of ... ” or “daughters of ... ” is used to indicate members of a group. So the sons of *Elohim* are members of a group of spiritual beings.
- The Bible claims there are powers and rulers in the heavenly realm with agency who are at work in ways very difficult for humans to be aware of.
- The rebellion of the sons of *Elohim* in Genesis 6:1-4 mirrors, inverts, and intensifies the rebellion of the humans in the garden in Genesis 3.

The Rebellion of the Sons of *Elohim*: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 6:1-4

The Rebellion of the Sons of Elohim

- a ¹ And it came about, when humanity began to multiply (רב) on the face of the land ,
b and daughters were born to/for them ,
b' ² the sons of Elohim saw the daughters of humanity that they were good
c and they took wives for themselves, whomever they chose.

- ³ and Yahweh said ,
a “My Spirit/breath will not dwell with humanity forever,
b because he also is flesh;
a' and his days will be one hundred and twenty years.”

- a ⁴ The Nephilim were in the land in those days,
and also afterward,
b when the sons of Elohim went
c into the daughters of humanity
c' and they bore children
b' to/for them ;
a' these are the mighty warriors who are from ancient time, men of the name.

Many modern readers struggle to understand what's happening in this story or its connection to the overall story in Genesis 1-11. This struggle is a sign of our distance from the shared cultural knowledge that is assumed by the biblical authors.

The biblical authors presuppose a whole body of understanding that is clear to someone who (1) has already internalized the entire Hebrew Bible and (2) has a basic knowledge of Mesopotamian history and Babylonian propaganda. It's difficult for modern readers to track because we don't share that ancient context.

Let's tackle this text with a series of questions that will illuminate the key issues.

Who Are the Sons of *Elohim*?

The phrase "sons of *Elohim*" (בני אלהים) is used five times in the Hebrew Bible, and it always refers to spiritual beings who inhabit the divine realm in God's presence, otherwise known as the divine council.

Job 1:6 (also 2:1) NASB*

Now there was a day when **the sons of God** came to present themselves before the LORD, and the one opposed [= the Satan] also came among them.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Job 38:4, 7 NASB

⁴ Where were you when I laid the foundation of the earth? ...

⁷ When the morning stars sang together, and all **the sons of God** shouted for joy?

There are two variant phrases found in Psalm 29:1, Psalm 89:7, and Psalm 82:6.

Psalm 29:1-2 NASB*

¹ Ascribe to the LORD, O **sons of God** [= sons of *El*],
ascribe to the LORD glory and strength.

² Ascribe to the LORD the glory due to his name;
worship the LORD in holy array.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 89:5-8 NASB*

⁵ The heavens will praise your wonders, Yahweh;
your faithfulness also in the assembly of **the holy ones**.

⁶ For **who in the skies** is comparable to the LORD?
Who among **the sons of God** [= sons of *El*] is like Yahweh,

⁷ an *El* greatly feared in **the council of the holy ones**,